

Raccoons and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Procyonidae
SPECIES	13

CLASSIFICATION NOTE

Some authorities group the lesser panda with the raccoon family. However, recent studies suggest that it should be classified in its own family, the Ailuridae and this is how it has been treated in this book.

This family is typified by the raccoons, which are well known for their mischievousness and dexterity. They will boldly approach humans for food and can use their highly mobile hands for opening doors and the like. In addition to raccoons, the family also includes coatis, ringtails, kinkajous, and olingos. Common characteristics include distinctive tail rings and a dark mask pattern on the face. The animals in this family are typically arboreal and have long tails to aid balance. All species in this family, except the coati, are nocturnal. Procyonids are found in the forests of the Americas.

Anatomy

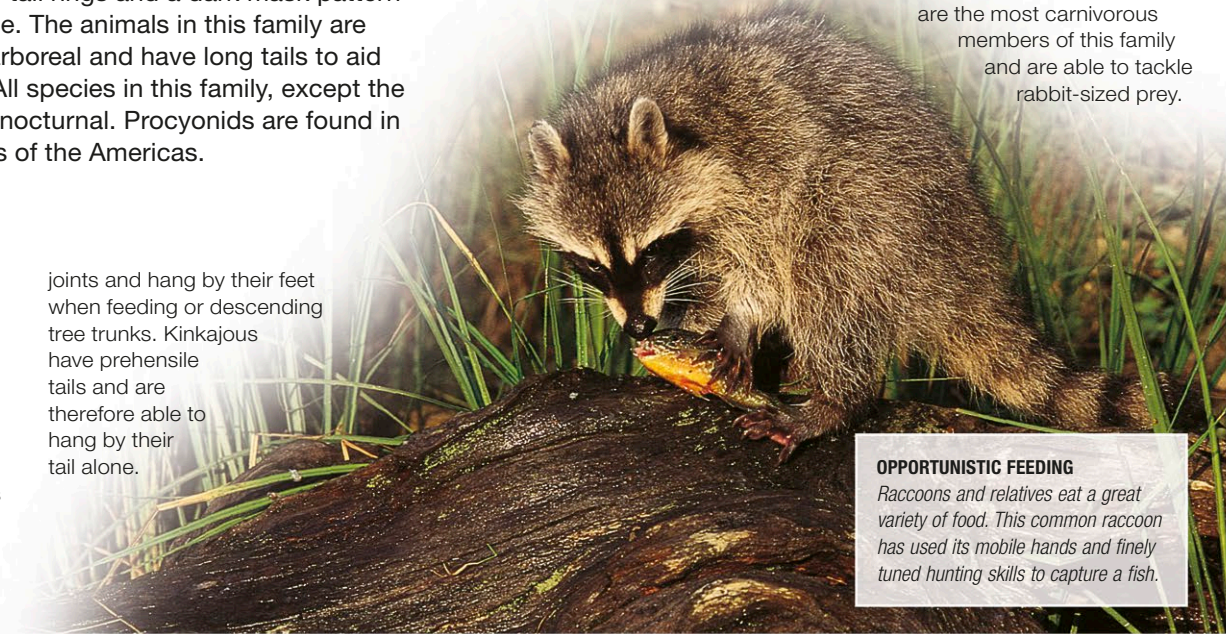
Members of the raccoon family are all medium-sized and short-legged, and have a flat-footed (plantigrade), bearlike gait. They commonly have a pointed snout, a relatively long body, a broad face, round or pointed ears, and brown or gray fur. All species have short claws and raccoons feature front paws developed into sensitive, mobile hands. Highly arboreal species, such as ringtails and kinkajous, have the ability to rotate their ankle

joints and hang by their feet when feeding or descending tree trunks. Kinkajous have prehensile tails and are therefore able to hang by their tail alone.

Feeding

Most species in this family are omnivorous, and their diet varies with location, season, and the availability of food sources. They will eat fruit, roots, shoots, and nuts, as well as insects and small vertebrates, such as birds, amphibians, and reptiles. Kinkajous mostly eat fruit and are important seed dispersers in

their rain-forest habitat. They also have long tongues so they can lap up nectar from flowers. Raccoons use their dextrous hands to reach into streams to feel for crustaceans, fish, and other prey. Their unfussy palate also brings them into urban areas, where they raid garbage cans and fearlessly solicit food from householders. The ringtail and coati are the most carnivorous members of this family and are able to tackle rabbit-sized prey.



OPPORTUNISTIC FEEDING

Raccoons and relatives eat a great variety of food. This common raccoon has used its mobile hands and finely tuned hunting skills to capture a fish.

Nasua nasua

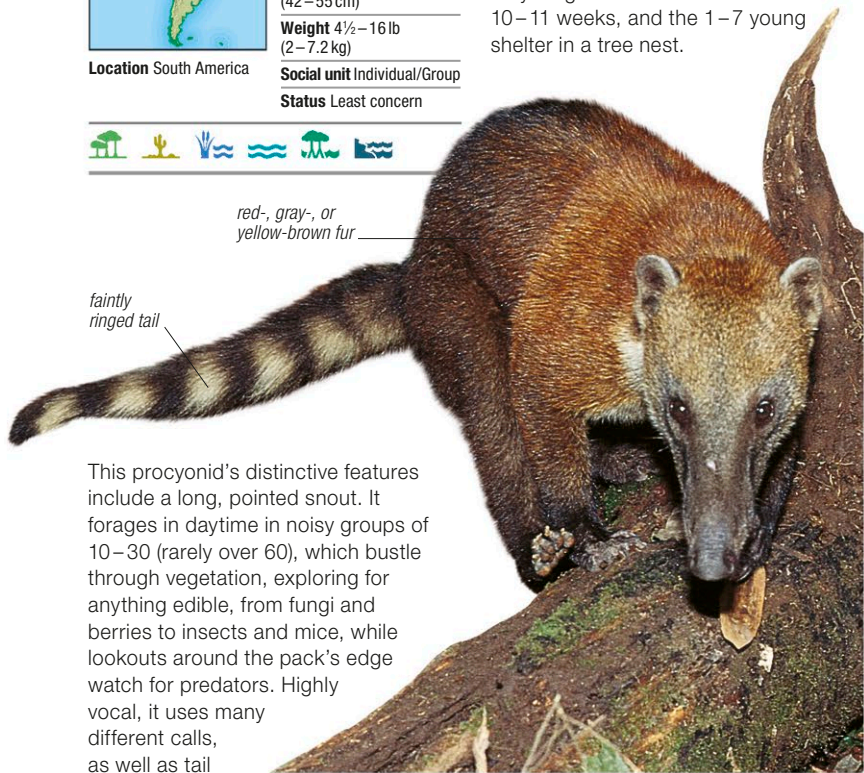
South American coati



Length 17–23 in (43–58 cm)
Tail 16½–22 in (42–55 cm)
Weight 4½–16 lb (2–7.2 kg)
Location South America
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Least concern



movements, to keep in contact. A barking alarm call sends coatis scurrying into dense foliage or the treetops, although they may turn and mob the attacker. The coati also sleeps among the branches. Adult males tend to be solitary and more carnivorous, even cannibalistic on young of their kind. Gestation is 10–11 weeks, and the 1–7 young shelter in a tree nest.



red-, gray-, or yellow-brown fur

faintly ringed tail

This procyonid's distinctive features include a long, pointed snout. It forages in daytime in noisy groups of 10–30 (rarely over 60), which bustle through vegetation, exploring for anything edible, from fungi and berries to insects and mice, while lookouts around the pack's edge watch for predators. Highly vocal, it uses many different calls, as well as tail

Bassariscus astutus

Ringtail



Length 12–16½ in (30–42 cm)
Tail 12–17½ in (31–44 cm)
Weight 1¾–3¼ lb (0.8–1.5 kg)
Location C. and W. USA to S. Mexico
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Also called the ringtailed cat or cacomistle, this slender, agile predator has a tail boldly ringed in black and white. The upper body is gray-brown or buff, with black eye rings and white muzzle and "eyebrows." Nocturnal and solitary, this procyonid hunts small birds, mammals, and reptiles, and also forages for grubs, raids birds' nests, and eats fruit and nuts. It marks its territory with droppings and urine and defends it against others of the same sex. Gestation is 51–54 days, with an average litter size of 1–4.

Bassaricyon gabbii

Northern olingo



Length 14–19½ in (35–49 cm)
Tail 16–21½ in (40–53 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.6 kg)
Location Central America to N. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This slim, almost catlike procyonid makes its home in most kinds of forest, especially moist, high-altitude cloud forest. It moves with great skill in the branches, rarely coming to the ground, using its strongly grasping hands and feet and its long, fluffy, nonprehensile tail for balance. Active at night, the northern olingo is solitary except during the breeding season, when female and male call loudly to each other. The northern olingo's main diet is fruit, but it also catches grubs and other small creatures.

